



Force to reckon with: Delhi SG Pipers boasts a formidable attacking line-up that includes India's best striker Sangita Kumari (front). GETTYIMAGES

Delhi SG Pipers

Men: The team pulled off the biggest heist, not during the auctions but before, by appointing P. R. Sreejesh as its Director of Hockey. The recently-retired Indian goalkeeper not only brought the latest insights and knowledge of the players up for auction but also played a part in assembling a strong support team, with Graham Reid and Shivendra Singh as coaches. This is reflected in the balance of Indian and

foreign players in the side, and the combination of senior and junior players.

The star player will be Germany's Christopher Ruhr, a player who can not only create goals for others but also step up to score himself when needed.

With two Olympic medals, junior and senior World Cup titles, and still

only 30, Ruhr will be the fulcrum around which the team revolves. Alongside him, Australia's Flynn Ogilvie and Ky Willot, Dutchman Jorrit Croon, Shamsheer Singh, and Raj Kumar Pal make up the best midfield in the competition.

The defence is a mixed bag, but the main concern is upfront. The team has put its faith in juniors — Dilraj Singh, Aditya Lalage, Sourabh Kushwaha — to score the goals, a gamble that could either pay off spectacularly, with spillover effects for the national team, or prove disastrous. Sreejesh will be hoping for the former.

Women: Delhi splurged on 17-year-old Sunelita Toppo and boasts a formidable attacking lineup that includes India's best striker in Sangita Kumari.

The team is effectively split into a foreign defence and an Indian attack featuring drag-flicker Deepika, Navneet Kaur, and Ishika, with Charlotte Watson as the sole overseas player in the forward line.

The defence is where the experience lies, with Stephanie De Groof, Brits Giselle Ansley and Elizabeth Ann Neal, Australian Miri Maroney, and goalkeeper Elodie Picard.

Interestingly, national team analytical coach Dave Smolenaars will be in charge of the team, and it remains to be seen if his expertise translates into an advantage for the girls.

UP Rudras

Men: Like the Soormas, the Rudras had a clear focus: secure Hardik Singh and build the team around him. The Indian midfield maestro, with the uncanny ability to run circles around the opposition, find gaps where none seem to exist, down the shutters at the back, and surge forward — all in the same

« Former national goalkeeper P. R. Sreejesh is the Director of Hockey at Delhi SG Pipers »